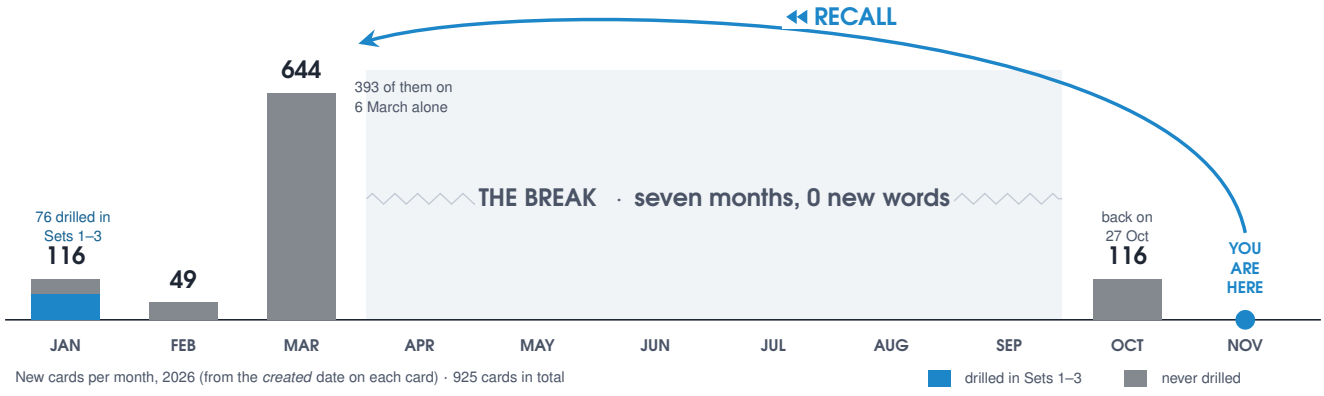
ENGLISH-VOCABULARY VAULT · 925 CARDS · COMEBACK REVIEW

RECALL

Rewind the vault. Get the words back on your tongue.

The words worth keeping from *Dragon Ball*, *Jujutsu Kaisen Modulo*, *My Hero Academia Vigilantes*, *Mushoku Tensei*, *Dr. Stone* and the rest of your vault — meanings, forgotten senses, phrasal verbs, idioms, register and British English — mixed the way you will actually meet them: in Leuven, on Discord, in the lab and in the news.



WHERE THE 925 CARDS CAME FROM



DBZ = Dragon Ball Z, JJK = Jujutsu Kaisen Modulo, MHA = My Hero Academia Vigilantes · smaller slices: MT 44 · DBS 27 · DS 18 · GT 7 · LIFE 5 · PB 4 · F1 1

HOW THIS REVIEW WORKS

1. **Retrieve, don't re-read.** Closed book: no vault, no dictionary, no key until you have finished a part. The effort of dragging a word out of memory is exactly what makes it stay.
2. **Say it out loud.** Before you write an answer, say the whole sentence at normal speed. The stutter disappears in your mouth, not on paper.
3. **Use your colours.** Blue = right first time, orange = small slip, red = wrong, then corrected.
4. **Tag your reds.** Every answer in the key carries a tag (`C` = collocation, `P` = phrasal verbs . . .). On the *Rundown* page, colour one square per red: your hottest rows tell you what to revisit.
5. **Three sessions, not a marathon.** Parts 1–3 → Parts 4–5 → Parts 6–7 + Rundown. After that, the rematch schedule on the last page takes over.

ICONS

Write · Speak · Think / puzzle · Timed · Dice · PT uses your Portuguese · UK British English

BRIEFING What a seven-month break does to 925 words

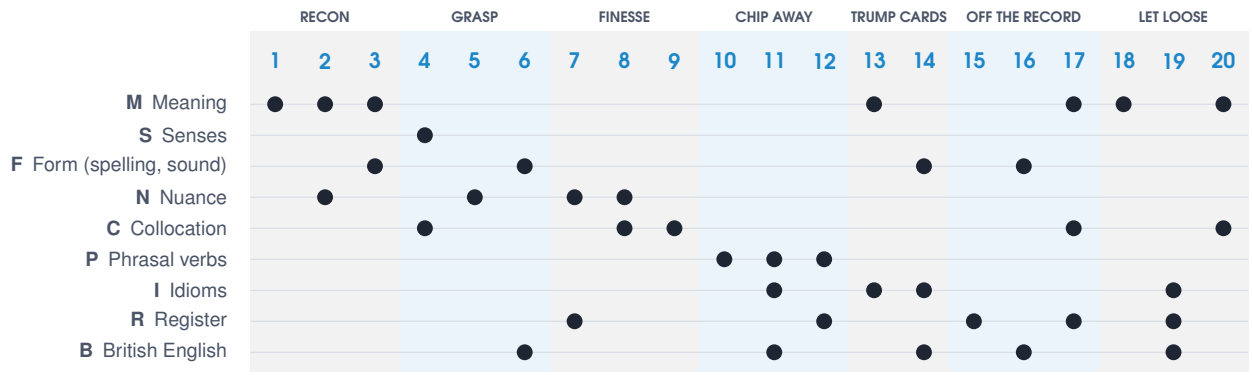
1. **Recognition outlives recall.** You will still *recognise* most of your words when you see them. What fades first is pulling them out on demand — in a seminar, on Discord, in a lab report. That is the stutter. So almost every exercise here makes you *produce* the word, not just spot it.
2. **Chunks fall apart.** Fluency lives in ready-made chunks — *pay through the nose*, *chip away at*, *be that as it may*. After a break they come back with the wrong particle or a missing word. Parts 4 and 5 rebuild them.
3. **Senses collapse.** Words with several meanings shrink back to the first one you met (usually the anime one): *floor, coast, toll, strain…* Part 2 brings the other meanings back.
4. **Your vault speaks American.** Most of it came from US dubs and subtitles — but you study British English. Part 6 converts.
5. **Not all 925 deserve equal time.** 644 cards entered the vault in three days of March and were never drilled. Nobody keeps that many from a single pass, so this review *triages*.

THE TRIAGE — how the words in this review were chosen

S	**Use it** at uni and in real life	Formal power words and discourse chunks: *assess, convey, deem, hinder, withhold, scrutiny, inherently, be that as it may, at the expense of…*
A	**Sound natural** talk, Discord, gaming	Phrasal verbs, idioms and people words: *pull off, chip away at, call it quits, turn a blind eye, a blessing in disguise, gullible, stuck-up…*
B	**Recognise it** reading and watching	Dramatic, fantasy-flavoured words: *foreboding, wrath, onslaught, perish, smithereens, envoy, decree…*
C	**Let it go** no drilling needed	Dub-only slang, cartoon insults, archaic or ultra-specific words: *tarnation, oogey, whippersnapper, doughboy, cruller, cephalopod, thee…*

This review drills tiers S and A, gives B a light touch and leaves C on the bench. The full *let-it-go* list is on the last page — permission granted.

WHAT EACH EXERCISE TRAINS (a dot = that kind of knowledge is tested there)



Every word in this review is a card in your vault. The answer key shows where each one came from (DBZ JJK MHA MT DS DBS GT PB LIFE) and in which month you added it, so you can open the card and re-read it after a mistake. All part titles are vault words too.

PART 1

RECON

Short for reconnaissance *(your JJK card). Scout what survived the break before you fight for the rest.*

1 Vault scan

M · meaning

Five seconds per item, no more. Tick one box: ✓ = *I could use it right now* ~ = *I know it when I see it* ✗ = *gone*. For every ✓, prove it on the line (a meaning or a tiny example). The four batches are four moments in your vault's life.

Before you start, predict: which batch survived best? A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D ☐

A JANUARY drilled in Sets 1–3

	✓	~	✗	prove it (only for ✓)
withstand	☐	☐	☐	
shrewd	☐	☐	☐	
ominous	☐	☐	☐	
ponder	☐	☐	☐	
grudge	☐	☐	☐	
ample	☐	☐	☐	
insidious	☐	☐	☐	
thereby	☐	☐	☐	
uncanny	☐	☐	☐	
loom	☐	☐	☐	
brazen	☐	☐	☐	
jeopardise	☐	☐	☐	

B FEBRUARY never drilled

	✓	~	✗	prove it (only for ✓)
breach	☐	☐	☐	
deterrent	☐	☐	☐	
withhold	☐	☐	☐	
strive	☐	☐	☐	
entrust	☐	☐	☐	
plummet	☐	☐	☐	
subtle	☐	☐	☐	
ward off	☐	☐	☐	
stir up	☐	☐	☐	
slack off	☐	☐	☐	
call it quits	☐	☐	☐	
heirloom	☐	☐	☐	

C MARCH the 644 · never drilled

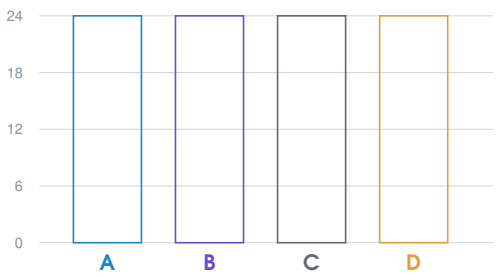
	✓	~	✗	prove it (only for ✓)
cope	☐	☐	☐	
convey	☐	☐	☐	
deem	☐	☐	☐	
gauge	☐	☐	☐	
heed	☐	☐	☐	
hindrance	☐	☐	☐	
oblivious	☐	☐	☐	
rampant	☐	☐	☐	
scrutiny	☐	☐	☐	
tangible	☐	☐	☐	
a blessing in disguise	☐	☐	☐	
keep tabs on	☐	☐	☐	

D OCTOBER fresh

	✓	~	✗	prove it (only for ✓)
be that as it may	☐	☐	☐	
convoluted	☐	☐	☐	
hone	☐	☐	☐	
impose	☐	☐	☐	
wrap your head around	☐	☐	☐	
contingency	☐	☐	☐	
folly	☐	☐	☐	
pledge	☐	☐	☐	
harrowing	☐	☐	☐	
balk (at)	☐	☐	☐	
seldom	☐	☐	☐	
delve into	☐	☐	☐	

Score it with the key. A ✓ only counts if your meaning is right. ✓ = 2 points, ~ = 1, ✗ = 0, so each batch is out of 24. Shade the bars.

If A beats C, you have just measured the *testing effect*: the words you were made to retrieve in January survived; the words that were only filed in March did not. That is why every exercise from here on is retrieval.



2 Decoys

M · meaning N · nuance

Circle the correct definition. Careful: the two wrong options are not random — each one is the definition of *another word in your vault*. Bonus point for every decoy you can name. Aim for under six minutes.

1 latent
a about to happen very soon
b present from birth, not learned
c existing, but not yet developed, active or visible
decoys: _____ / _____

2 leniency
a a lack of care and attention
b the quality of being less strict than expected when punishing
c a feeling of strong dislike
decoys: _____ / _____

3 plight
a a serious public promise
b an urgent, emotional request
c a difficult or dangerous situation
decoys: _____ / _____

4 forfeit
a to lose or give something up as a penalty
b to refuse to give something that is wanted
c to make secret information known
decoys: _____ / _____

5 discretion
a care not to embarrass anyone or reveal private things
b close and careful examination
c praise that is too much, or not sincere
decoys: _____ / _____

6 linger
a to walk slowly and casually, for pleasure
b to stay longer than necessary; to continue to exist
c to worry about something
decoys: _____ / _____

7 dwindle
a to fall suddenly from a high level
b to become worse in quality or behaviour
c to become gradually smaller or fewer
decoys: _____ / _____

8 engulf
a to surround or cover something completely
b to trap someone, as if in a net
c to destroy completely
decoys: _____ / _____

9 gullible
a not aware of what is happening around you
b easily tricked or deceived
c not easily convinced; full of doubt
decoys: _____ / _____

10 bleak
a (of land) too poor for plants to grow
b sad and quiet, with no energy
c cold and empty; offering little hope
decoys: _____ / _____

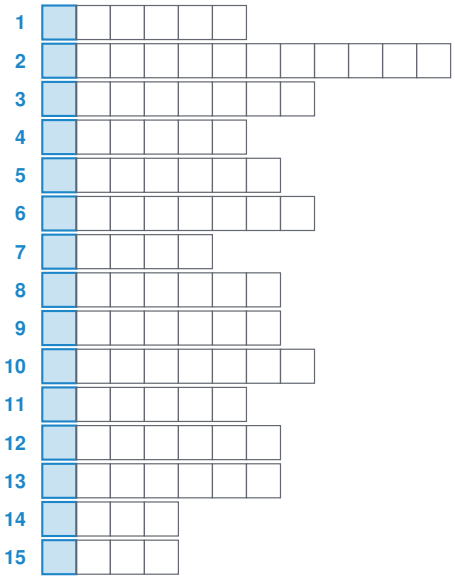
11 devious
a rude and showing no respect
b dishonest in a clever, indirect way
c wicked or criminal in nature
decoys: _____ / _____

12 meagre
a small in amount and not enough
b small and weak (of a person)
c enough, or more than enough
decoys: _____ / _____

3 Here goes nothing

M · meaning F · spelling

Solve the clues and write one letter per box. The shaded first column hides a phrase from your vault — if it reads like nonsense, one of your answers is wrong. That is the self-check.



1 A person who lives alone and avoids other people. *After exam week I turn into a total . . .*

2 Making you feel extremely happy and full of energy: *an . . . final lap.*

3 Famous and respected for something: *Leuven is . . . for its university and its beer.*

4 To treat two things as the same: *Don't . . . being busy with being productive.*

5 A quick, incomplete view: *I caught a . . . of the exam paper on the desk.*

6 To fail to notice: *It's easy to . . . a minus sign in a long derivation.*

7 To force a tenant to leave a property, usually by law.

8 Having far too much work: *I'm . . . this week — three deadlines.*

9 To fail to look after something: *Don't . . . your sleep in exam season.*

10 Complete; or openly and directly: *an . . . lie · she refused . . .*

11 To make small repairs or changes, often as an amateur: *he loves to . . . with old PCs.*

12 A small number — or a person who is hard to control: *Only a . . . came. · That puppy is a real . . .*

13 *To be . . . to do something* = to want to do it very much, very soon.

14 Too interested in other people's private lives.

15 Courage and determination to keep going when things get hard.

The hidden phrase: _____ When would you say it? _____

PART 2 GRASP

Get a grip on the meaning — and then on the other meanings. Plus spelling and sound.

4 One word, three jobs

S · senses C · collocation

One word from your vault fits all three gaps — in three different senses. Write it once, in the box. The gaps may need a different form (*-s, -ed, -ing*). Most of these senses are on your cards; a few are the ones your cards forgot.

1
a I've never been very _____ on horror films, to be honest.
b You need a _____ eye to spot a typo in a 40-page lab report.
c Careful — the new kitchen knife has a really _____ edge.

2
a We spent Sunday on the Belgian _____, eating waffles in the wind.
b He _____ through first year without opening a single book.
c The bike _____ down the hill while I took my feet off the pedals.

3 a Our kot is on the top _____ — and there's no lift, of course.
b Her question completely _____ me; I had no idea what to say.
c After the talk, the chair gave the _____ to the audience for questions.

4 a We won by _____ luck — their best player had food poisoning.
b The coastal path ends at a _____ drop into the sea.
c She wore a _____, almost see-through blouse over a black top.

5 a The death _____ from the floods has risen to thirty.
b On most French motorways you have to pay a _____.
c Somewhere in the old town, a church bell began to _____.

6 a Most arguments in our house _____ from one thing: the washing-up.
b The new rules are meant to _____ the flow of fake news.
c Cut each flower's _____ at an angle before you put it in water.

7 a There's been a _____ in demand for student rooms this year.
b I felt a _____ of panic when I turned over the exam paper.
c A power _____ fried my PC's motherboard during the storm.

8 a The firefighter who saved the kitten was _____ as a hero.
b Raise your arm to _____ a taxi.
c Lumps of _____ the size of marbles dented every car in the street.

9 a A fish bone got _____ in his throat.
b We decided to _____ a formal complaint with the university.
c For the ski trip we rented a wooden _____ in the Alps.

10 a The deadline is putting a lot of _____ on the whole team.
b I _____ a muscle in my calf on my long run.
c _____ the pasta, but keep a cup of the cooking water.

5 Volume knobs

N · nuance

Each knob turns one idea up from weakest to strongest. Put the words in order on the lines. Near-synonyms are where meaning gets fuzzy after a break — this is how you sharpen it.

EFFORT How hard are you working?

coast · slack off · work your tail off · buckle down

weakest strongest

_____ _____ _____ _____

RESISTANCE How firmly are you saying no?

reluctant · defiant · hesitant · balk at

weakest strongest

_____ _____ _____ _____

TROUBLE How bad is it?

calamity · snag · ordeal

weakest strongest

_____ _____ _____

CONFLICT How violent is it?

onslaught · bickering · quarrel

weakest strongest

_____ _____ _____

LAUGHTER How loud is it?

crack up · grin · giggle

weakest strongest

_____ _____ _____

NERVE How shameless is it?

brazen · sassy · impudent

weakest strongest

_____ _____ _____

Turn it up. Write one sentence about your last week using the *strongest* word from any two knobs.

6 Mic check

F · spelling & sound B · British UK

Half of understanding British players on voice chat is knowing how words *sound*; half of writing well is knowing how they are *spelt*. Four quick checks.

A Spellcheck can't save you. Each sentence has one wrong word that *sounds* right. Write the correct word.

1 I've been working my tale off for this exam. _____

2 The bus fair to Heverlee went up again. _____

3 Running a half-marathon in under two hours is quite a feet. _____

4 Stop medalling in my love life! _____

5 The bins reak in this heat. _____

6 My soul reason for joining was the free pizza. _____

7 Add two cups of flower and a pinch of salt. _____

8 I booked a long-hall flight to São Paulo. _____

B Silent letters. Circle every letter you do *not* pronounce.

subtle	heirloom	numb	knack	wrestling
wrath	reigning	psyche	doughy	listen up

C The British /ɑː/. In standard southern British English, *some* words with the letter *a* take the long vowel of *car*, where Americans say the short vowel of *cat*. Tick the six that do.

☐ grasp	☐ ample	☐ chant	☐ anvil	☐ slander	☐ dashing
☐ scram	☐ rascal	☐ racket	☐ half-pint	☐ tandem	☐ laughingstock

D Stress. Underline the stressed syllable.

un·pre·ce·den·ted	om·ni·scient	ex·em·pla·ry	ca·la·mi·ty	sab·ba·ti·cal
con·tin·gen·cy	bu·reau·crat	vo·ci·fer·ous·ly	con·vo·lu·ted	le·ni·en·cy

Say it, then check it. Read Part D aloud three times and record yourself. Then play the UK audio for each word on the Cambridge Dictionary website and compare. One word you got wrong = one note on that card in your vault.

PART 3

FINESSE

Delicate skill (your MHA card). Same family, different jobs: connotation, near-synonyms and the company words keep.

7 Compliment or insult?

N · connotation R · register

Someone at your student job — or in your Discord server — describes you with one of these words. Is it a **C**ompliment, an **I**nsult, or does it **D**epend (on context, tone, or which side of the Atlantic you are on)? Write C, I or D in the box.

☐ shrewd	☐ gullible	☐ resourceful	☐ stuck-up
☐ nimble	☐ cunning	☐ nosy	☐ exemplary
☐ scrappy	☐ cocky	☐ feisty	☐ naive
☐ smooth-talking	☐ laid-back	☐ pigheaded	☐ defiant
☐ dashing	☐ obnoxious	☐ mischievous	☐ portly

Flip it. Choose one of your D words. Write a sentence where it is praise and one where it stings.

8 Not quite twins

N · near-synonyms C · collocation

Near-synonyms are your vault's most dangerous neighbours. Map what makes each one different, then use the map.

A Stopping things. Tick *every* feature that applies.

	①	②	③	④	⑤	⑥
hinder	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
impede	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
thwart	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
foil	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
ward off	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
fend off	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
hold off	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

① slows it down or makes it harder (it may still happen)
② stops a plan, plot or attempt completely
③ keeps a danger, an illness or an attacker away
④ also works with difficult questions or criticism
⑤ can also mean *wait before doing something*
⑥ formal — at home in reports and essays

a Police _____ a plot to steal paintings from the museum.

b Garlic was once believed to _____ evil spirits.

c Heavy snow _____ the rescue effort for two days.

d The minister _____ awkward questions about the budget.

e Let's _____ booking the flights until the prices drop.

f *(lab report)* Insufficient lighting may _____ the operator's concentration.

B Who works for whom? Tick the *one* feature that defines each word best.

	①	②	③	④	⑤	⑥
henchman	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
sidekick	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
crony	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
lackey	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
underling	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
pawn	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

① does the dirty work for a villain or a crime boss
② a loyal companion — often the funny one
③ a friend who gets unfair favours (politics, business)
④ servile: will do anything they are told
⑤ simply lower in rank — said with contempt
⑥ used or manipulated by someone more powerful

g The president gave all the top jobs to his _____.

h Every superhero needs a wisecracking _____.

i The villain sent two _____ to break into the lab.

j I'm nobody's _____ — fetch your own coffee.

k She realised she had been a _____ in their game all along.

l Our manager never talks to his _____; he just sends emails.

C Pick the precise one.

m Babies have an [innate / inherent] ability to recognise faces.

n Every investment carries an [innate / inherent] risk.

o I [seldom / scarcely / merely] go out on weeknights.

p I could [seldom / scarcely / merely] hear him over the music.

q It's [seldom / scarcely / merely] a scratch — stop fussing.

r This is a matter of the [utmost / upmost] importance.

s Can you [assure / ensure] that the lab is locked tonight?

t Police are still trying to establish the suspect's [whereabouts / venue].

9 The odd one out

C · collocation

Three of the nouns are natural partners of the verb; one is not. Cross out the intruder, then write the verb it *does* go with. These pairs are exactly what turns a 7.5 into an 8 in writing.

HARBOUR
a grudge
doubts
suspicions
a threat

odd one goes with: _____

IMPOSE
a ban
a curfew
a fine
a question

odd one goes with: _____

WITHHOLD
information
a meeting
payment
consent

odd one goes with: _____

EVOKE
memories
sympathy
a response
a decision

odd one goes with: _____

FORFEIT
the match
a deposit
a promise
the right to appeal

odd one goes with: _____

MUSTER
courage
the strength
attention
support

odd one goes with: _____

WIELD
power
influence
a sword
an opinion

odd one goes with: _____

HONE
your skills
a habit
a technique
your craft

odd one goes with: _____

BREACH
a contract
a record
security
the rules

odd one goes with: _____

STRIKE
a deal
a balance
a chord
a conclusion

odd one goes with: _____

LODGE
a complaint
an appeal
a compliment
an objection

odd one goes with: _____

TAP INTO
a market
your potential
a deadline
a resource

odd one goes with: _____

PART 4

CHIP AWAY

Phrasal verbs: small words doing big work. They come back the way you lost them — bit by bit.

10 Particle physics

P · phrasal verbs

The little word after the verb is not random: each particle carries a core meaning. Use the map to guess the particle you have forgotten — you are an engineer, so treat it like physics.



A Fill in the particle.

1 **fend** _____ — keep an attacker or a question away

2 **ward** _____ — keep an illness or danger away

3 **brush** _____ — dismiss someone or an idea rudely

4 **slack** _____ — work less hard than you should

5 **drift** _____ — fall asleep slowly

6 **pull** _____ — succeed at something difficult

7 **patch** _____ — repair quickly; make friends again

8 **stir** _____ — deliberately cause trouble

9 **pile** _____ — accumulate

10 **crack** _____ — burst out laughing

11 **suck** _____ **to** — flatter someone to get an advantage

12 **barge** _____ — enter rudely, without asking

13 **butt** _____ — interrupt a conversation

14 **step** _____ — get involved to help or to stop something

15 **tap** _____ — access and use a resource

16 **pipe** _____ — be quieter (not polite!)

17 **buckle** _____ — start working seriously

18 **chip** _____ **at** — reduce gradually, bit by bit

19 **tag** _____ — go with someone, often uninvited

20 **snap** _____ **of it** — stop feeling sorry for yourself

B Same family, different job. Choose the right phrasal verb and put it in the right form.

a All those extra hours in the lab finally _____. [pay off / pull off]

b Nobody thought we could win from 0–2 down, but we _____ it _____! [pay off / pull off]

c Sorry to _____, but your laptop is on fire. [barge in / butt in]

d He _____ into my room without knocking. [barge / butt]

e Vitamin C won't _____ a cold, whatever your gran says. [ward off / fend off]

f The minister _____ questions about the scandal all morning. [warded off / fended off]

11 From the casters' desk

P · phrasal verbs I · idioms B · British

UK

Two British casters call the deciding map of a (fictional) university esports final. Complete the commentary with the chunks in the box — each one once, two are left over. Change nothing: the form you need is in the box.

right off the bat · on the back foot · ambush · fend · chipping away · holding · toe-to-toe · budge · stalemate · trump card · here goes nothing · tip the scales · crumbling · shoo-in · pulled · cracking · turn the tide · keep tabs on · call it quits

UNIVERSITY ESPORTS LEAGUE · GRAND FINAL · MAP 3 LEUVEN LIONS vs GHENT GARGOYLES

J Jamie
Welcome back to the grand final! It's one map apiece, and 1 _____ the Lions have been 2 _____ on this one.

P Priya
They really have. Ghent opened with a brilliant 3 _____ at the first choke point, and Leuven just couldn't 4 _____ it off.

J Jamie
But look at this — their tank is slowly 5 _____ at the shield... and they're 6 _____ Ghent off the point!

P Priya
It's 7 _____ in the middle now, and neither team will 8 _____ an inch.

J Jamie
A complete 9 _____ — and the clock is ticking.

P Priya
Leuven need something special. Have they still got their 10 _____?

J Jamie
They have! The support dives in — 11 _____! — and WHAT. A. PLAY. That could 12 _____!

P Priya
Ghent are 13 _____! Their whole formation is falling apart!

J Jamie
They were the 14 _____ for the title this morning, and Leuven have just 15 _____ it off!

P Priya
What a 16 _____ final. That, ladies and gentlemen, is how you 17 _____!

Cast it. Read the commentary aloud at caster speed — fast, excited, British (*Leuven* ***are***, *Ghent* ***are***: British English often treats teams as plural). Then record 30 seconds on your own last ranked match using at least five chunks from the box.

12 Suit & tie

P · phrasal verbs R · register

Phrasal verbs make you sound natural in speech; in a report or a formal email, their one-word cousins do the job. Most of the formal words below are in your vault too.

A Match each casual expression to its formal equivalent. Two formal words are left over.

1 put up with _____
2 come by (= obtain) _____
3 tap into _____
4 chip away at _____
5 hold off (an attack) _____
6 stir up (memories) _____
7 slack off (on your work) _____
8 keep back (information) _____
9 give up (a right, control) _____
10 cut short _____

a withhold
b diminish
c relinquish
d acquire
e evoke
f halt
g convey
h tolerate
i neglect
j commence
k harness
l withstand

B Save Daan from himself. Your lab partner wants to send this to Professor Claes. Rewrite it so that she is happy to receive it: keep every piece of information, change the register.

To: Prof. Claes Subject: lab report lol

hey prof, long story short, our experiment totally backfired: the sensor got busted and we had to call it quits halfway through. we've been swamped with other deadlines and kinda slacked off on the write-up, my bad. can we get a couple more days? we won't let stuff pile up again, promise!! cheers, Daan

PART 5

TRUMP CARDS

Idioms and fixed expressions: the chunks that win the round — but only if every word is in the right place.

13 Idiom exchange

I · idioms M · meaning PT

Your Portuguese is a shortcut — and a trap. Match each Brazilian expression to the English idiom from your vault that does the same job. Then tick **S** if the two use the *same picture* (*maçã podre = bad apple*) or **D** if the picture is *different* (that is where translating word for word goes wrong).

turn a blind eye · pay through the nose · bite off more than you can chew · be caught red-handed · a trump card · call it quits · right off the bat · safe and sound · turn the tide · a blessing in disguise · a bad apple · off the record · put down roots · a party pooper · keep tabs on · dust off · no skin off my nose · the writing's on the wall

1 *fazer vista grossa (para algo)*
→ _____ S☐ D☐

2 *pagar os olhos da cara*
→ _____ S☐ D☐

3 *dar um passo maior que a perna*
→ _____ S☐ D☐

4 *ser pego com a mão na massa*
→ _____ S☐ D☐

5 *ter uma carta na manga*
→ _____ S☐ D☐

6 *jogar a toalha*
→ _____ S☐ D☐

7 *logo de cara*
→ _____ S☐ D☐

8 *são e salvo*
→ _____ S☐ D☐

9 *virar o jogo*
→ _____ S☐ D☐

10 *há males que vêm para o bem*
→ _____ S☐ D☐

11 *uma maçã podre*
→ _____ S☐ D☐

12 *falar em off*
→ _____ S☐ D☐

13 *criar raízes*
→ _____ S☐ D☐

14 *um estraga-prazeres*
→ _____ S☐ D☐

15 *ficar de olho em (alguém)*
→ _____ S☐ D☐

16 *tirar a poeira de (algo)*
→ _____ S☐ D☐

B Three-second translations. Say each sentence in English within three seconds, then write it. Use an idiom from above.

1 *Paguei os olhos da cara por esse kot, e o aquecimento nem funciona.*

2 *O professor fez vista grossa quando a gente entregou o relatório atrasado.*

3 *Acho que dei um passo maior que a perna: três disciplinas de laboratório no mesmo semestre.*

4 *No fim, perder aquele estágio foi um mal que veio para o bem.*

5 *Ele foi pego com a mão na massa colando na prova.*

6 *Logo de cara, eu percebi que a gente ia perder.*

14 Broken idioms

I · idioms F · form B · British

Idioms are frozen: change one word and they break. Most of these sentences have *one* wrong word — write the correct one. But three of them are perfectly fine (one variant is even the British favourite): tick the box for those.

		✓	correct word
1	She paid through the mouth for those concert tickets.	☐	
2	The government turned a blind ear to the housing crisis.	☐	
3	Failing that module turned out to be a blessing in costume.	☐	
4	We lost, but they won fair and round.	☐	
5	After the storm, the hikers got home safe and sane.	☐	
6	Right off the stick, I knew it was a terrible idea.	☐	
7	My banking app keeps tabs of everything I spend.	☐	
8	I'm no spring hen — I need eight hours of sleep.	☐	
9	"Fancy a waffle?" — "Well, if you twist my leg. . ."	☐	
10	Don't be such a party popper — stay till midnight!	☐	
11	She's a shoe-in for the scholarship.	☐	
12	Be that as it might, we still need a plan.	☐	
13	From here on in, we play it safe.	☐	
14	To cut a long story short, we missed the last train.	☐	
15	The shop's been empty for months — the writing's on the door.	☐	
16	His joke sank like a stone.	☐	

PART 6

OFF THE RECORD

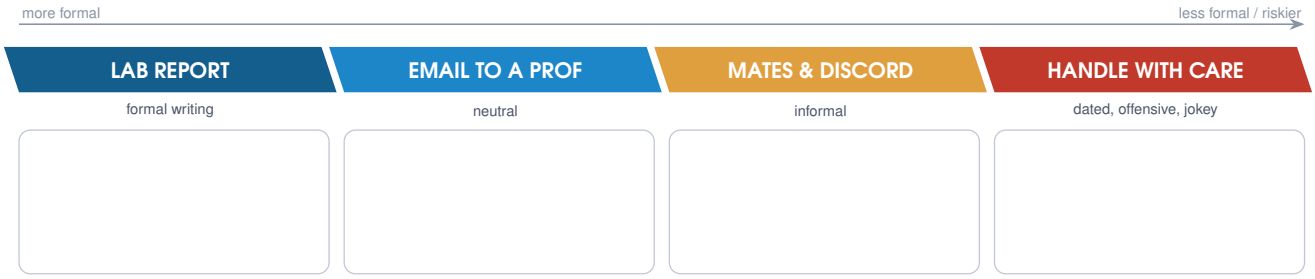
Who you are talking to changes the word: register, British English and the language of the news.

15 Where can I say it?

R · register

Write the number of each expression in the band where it naturally lives. Your vault cards carry register labels (*Formal*, *Informal*, *offensive*…) — this is where they start to matter.

1 commence	6 pipe down	11 on behalf of	16 sissy
2 a cinch	7 by all accounts	12 whippersnapper	17 thereby
3 schmuck	8 uppity	13 substantially	18 long story short
4 as of Monday	9 deem	14 bummer	19 be that as it may
5 akin to	10 obvi	15 all along	20 tarnation



Put band 1 to work. Write two sentences for your Integrated Lab report using at least two band-1 words.

16 Transatlantic customs

B · British F · spelling UK

Much of your vault arrived from American dubs and subtitles. Time to clear it through British customs.

A Spelling passport. Circle the British spelling. If both spellings are fine in the UK, circle both.

1 meager · meagre	6 maneuver · manoeuvre	11 specialty · speciality
2 savory · savoury	7 installment · instalment	12 jeopardize · jeopardise
3 skeptical · sceptical	8 caliber · calibre	13 spelled · spelt
4 smoldering · smouldering	9 plowing · ploughing	
5 counseling · counselling	10 unraveled · unravelled	

B Re-dub it for Lotte. Jake from Ohio sent this to your Flemish friend Lotte. Rewrite the thirteen underlined bits the way someone in London would say or spell them.

Hey Lotte! To make a long story short[1], my new roommate[2] is driving me nuts. He's been too big for his britches[3] since he became a full-fledged[4] member of the robotics team. Yesterday he left the trash[5] by the door all day, unplugged my laptop from the outlet[6] to charge his drone, and promised to do the dishes[7] from here on out[8]. Yeah, right. I wouldn't touch his chili[9] with a ten-foot pole[10], either. Anyway — cake at mine on Friday? I'll cover it in sprinkles[11], obvi[12]. It's a vicious cycle[13]: I bake when I'm stressed, then I'm stressed because I baked.

1 _____ 6 _____ 11 _____

2 _____ 7 _____ 12 _____

3 _____ 8 _____ 13 _____

4 _____ 9 _____

5 _____ 10 _____

C Same word, British meaning. In a conversation in the UK, what does the underlined word most likely mean? Circle a or b.

1 "That plan is completely mad."
a angry b crazy

2 "He slipped on the ice and landed on his bum."
a a homeless man b his bottom

3 "Three lectures and a shift at work — I'm whacked."
a exhausted b crazy

4 "The council has launched a new recycling scheme."
a a dishonest plot b an official plan

5 "Can't play tonight, sorry — my mocks are next week."
a practice exams b jokes about me

6 "The landlord pulled me a pint and asked about Brazil."
a the owner of my flat b the person who runs the pub

17 The Daily Vault

C · collocation M · meaning R · register

UK

British headlines are a language of their own: short, punchy words, no articles, present simple for things that already happened. Complete today's front page with the words in the box (two are left over).

soar · slashes · engulf · toll · hailed · thwarting · pledges · rampant · breach · disclose · looms · stalemate · bombshell · unveils · topple · unprecedented · farce · spree · plummet · cull

THE DAILY VAULT

Sunday 1 November 2026 Issue no. 925 Fictional, but very British

BUS FARES TO 1 _____ AS COUNCIL 2 _____ STUDENT DISCOUNTS

Leuven students face a winter of walking.

FLASH FLOODS 3 _____ VILLAGES — DEATH 4 _____ RISES TO 12

Rescue teams work through the night.

STUDENT 5 _____ AS HERO AFTER 6 _____ CAMPUS HACK

"I just noticed a weird log file," says engineering fresher.

MAYOR 7 _____ TO TACKLE 8 _____ RENTS

Landlords "disappointed".

UNI ADMITS DATA 9 _____, REFUSES TO 10 _____ HOW MANY AFFECTED

RAIL STRIKE 11 _____ AS PAY TALKS END IN 12 _____

Commuters told to work from home.

13 _____ REPORT: CARE HOMES ACCUSED OF DECADES OF NEGLECT

GOVERNMENT 14 _____ PLAN TO CUT ENERGY BILLS

AMATEURS 15 _____ CHAMPIONS IN 16 _____ CUP UPSET

Fourth-tier side stun the holders 2–1.

TRIAL DESCENDS INTO 17 _____ AS JUDGE NODS OFF

TEEN'S £3,000 GAMING 18 _____ ON MUM'S CARD

B Headline decoder.

a Headline 1 says *TO* + verb. What does that tell you about time?

b The cup headline uses the present simple. When did the match happen?

c Rewrite the mayor's headline as a normal sentence, with articles and a full verb phrase.

PART 7

LET LOOSE

Stop holding back: explain, improvise, tell stories. This is where the stutter goes.

18 Taboo

M · meaning

Explain each word out loud in under 30 seconds — as if to a classmate who has never heard it — *without* saying the word itself or the three forbidden words. Record yourself; if you freeze, that word goes on your comeback list. This trains exactly what the break took away: talking your way around a gap without stopping.

HEIRLOOM ✗family ✗old ✗valuable	**RIP-OFF** ✗expensive ✗price ✗cheat	**SHOO-IN** ✗win ✗certain ✗favourite
GRUDGE ✗angry ✗forgive ✗past	**SABBATICAL** ✗break ✗year ✗work	**WHEREABOUTS** ✗where ✗place ✗location
CLIFFHANGER ✗end ✗episode ✗suspense	**PEP TALK** ✗motivate ✗speech ✗coach	**TRUMP CARD** ✗card ✗advantage ✗secret
KNACK ✗skill ✗talent ✗good at	**TINFOIL HAT** ✗conspiracy ✗crazy ✗aluminium	**LANDLORD** ✗rent ✗house ✗owner

19 Hot seat

I · idioms R · register B · British

Answer each question out loud for 30–45 seconds. Two rules: use the **bold** chunk, and slip in one *discourse marker* from the deck (tick it; by the end, use all eight — markers buy you thinking time without sounding stuck). Record your three best answers and count the pauses longer than two seconds. Do the same on Day 7 of your rematch: fewer pauses is the whole point.

☐ as far as I'm concerned ☐ be that as it may ☐ to cut a long story short ☐ by all accounts
☐ all along ☐ every now and then ☐ frankly ☐ merely

1 What's something in Leuven that's a total **rip-off**?

2 Tell me about a plan of yours that **backfired**.

3 What's a skill you want to **hone** this year — and how?

4 When did you last **bite off more than you could chew**?

5 What's your **trump card** in an exam — or in a ranked match?

6 What's something you simply **can't abide**?

7 Describe a **lucky break** you've had.

8 Who did you **hold in high esteem** as a kid, and why?

9 Have you ever been **caught red-handed**? Doing what?

10 What would make you **call it quits** on a game for good?

11 What has turned out to be **a blessing in disguise** for you?

12 What are you **keen on** at the moment? (Say it the British way: *I'm really keen on. . .*)

20 Loot-box mini-saga

C · collocation M · meaning

Roll two dice five times: first die = row, second die = column. (No dice? Use any online dice roller.) Then write a **mini-saga**: a complete story in *exactly* 50 words — not 49, not 51; the title doesn't count — using all five words you rolled. Forms can change (*backfire → backfired*). Topic ideas: *my first week in Leuven · the experiment that went wrong · the match we threw · a message I shouldn't have sent*.

	⚀	⚁	⚂	⚃	⚄	⚅
⚀	backfire	swamped	rip-off	lucky break	chip away at	reluctant
⚁	overlook	grudge	hone	tinker	on edge	dread
⚂	pull off	bleak	keen on	call it quits	sheer	stray
⚃	a blessing in disguise	cope	landlord	glimpse	outright	linger
⚄	drag on	nosy	put down roots	plummet	exhilarating	grit
⚅	turn a blind eye	whereabouts	scrutiny	budge	worn out	here goes nothing

Your loot: 1 _____ 2 _____ 3 _____ 4 _____ 5 _____

Title: _____

Word count: ____ Check: ☐ exactly 50 ☐ all five words ☐ forms and partners right (*tinker **with**, keen **on***)

AFTER THE MATCH

RUNDOWN

A summary of the main points (your JJK card). Find your weak spots, plan the rematch, let the rest go.

1 YOUR REDS, BY TAG — colour one square for every red answer (wrong, then corrected). Two or more in a row = your next focus.

			then redo, closed book
M	Meaning	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	Ex 2 and 13 → re-read the cards of every red
S	Senses	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	Ex 4 → add the missing sense to the card
F	Form: spelling & sound	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	Ex 6 and 14 → say the words with the UK audio
N	Nuance	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	Ex 5, 7 and 8
C	Collocation	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	Ex 9 and 17 → one new sentence per red
P	Phrasal verbs	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	Ex 10 and 11 → use the particle map
I	Idioms	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	Ex 13 and 14 → say each red idiom five times
R	Register	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	Ex 12 and 15
B	British English	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	Ex 6C and 16

2 MY COMEBACK WORDS — the reds that hurt most. A new sentence about *your* life makes them stick.

WORD	WHAT WENT WRONG	MY NEW SENTENCE

3 REMATCH SCHEDULE — spaced retrieval: each comeback is a little harder, and that is exactly why it works.

TODAY	DAY 2	DAY 3	DAY 7	DAY 21
Parts 1–3	**Parts 4–5**	**Parts 6–7**	**Reds only**	**Vault scan again**
retrieve, tag the reds	phrasal verbs, idioms	+ fill in this page	Ex 2, 4, 9, 10, 14	compare your bars
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Vault homework (5 minutes). Open the card behind every red and add `recall` to its `tags:` list. Before each rematch, search `tag:#recall` in Obsidian and read only those cards. When a word has survived Day 21, remove the tag — it has earned it.

4 LET IT GO — tier C: recognise these if they come up, but don't spend review time on them.

tarnation · oogey · yeller · whippersnapper · even-steven · doughboy · nickel · batter up · cruller · eggrolls · calamari · cephalopod · soybean · shortcake · thee · whence · beseech · eyeholes · slap kick · knick · rash guard · the needles and thread. . .

Why these? Dub-only or archaic slang, food and animal words you will never need to produce, and lines that only make sense inside one scene. Your brain has better things to do in exam season.